

Outsmart Google?

That is exactly what contestants in the SEO (Search Engine Optimization) Challenge, carried online via SearchGuild.com, were told to do. Contestants had to increase their Google ranking for the search term 'nigritude ultramarine'.

Basically in Latin, this means 'dark blue', which comes from one of the co-sponsors-Dark-Blue, an Australian marketing company. "The competition really gives the opportunity to stand back and say this is what one engine does badly and another does better," said Chris Ridings, owner of SearchGuild.com, the other co-sponsor, in an interview to Wired.com. The

contestants were allowed any means, even underhanded ones, to improve rankings.

"If the point of the competition is to prove which methods work and don't work, then it's silly to place rules that say you can't use such and such a technique," Ridings reckoned. "If they really can't use it then the assumption is that Google would boot them out of the index, so they wouldn't win."

The first round-winner was Brandon Suit, an online community owner. Phillip Lenssen, a blogger who writes about Google, was placed second.

Gmail in trouble

The Californian state senate voted 24 to eight for a bill to introduce safeguards to protect users from prying e-mail services that scan mailboxes to display advertisements.

Though Gmail, Google's somewhat controversial e-mail service, wasn't specifically mentioned, it's pretty obvious which 'prying e-mail service' the senate was voting against.

Drafted by Senator Liz

Figueroa, it allows e-mail providers to go through message text for advertising, spam and malicious code, but bars them from leaking this information to third parties, or letting their staff take a peek into e-mails without consent.

The State Assembly still needs to pass the bill before it becomes a law, but we're more interested in how Google will circumvent this setback.

Linus accused of code-lifting

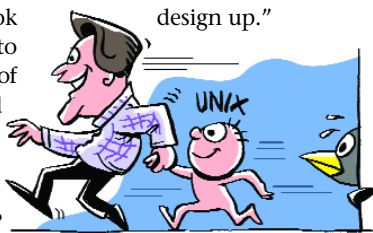
So did Linus Torvalds really create the Linux kernel, or was it actually Andrew Tanenbaum's baby? That's the question circulating the globe.

A 92-page booklet by a 12-man think tank called the Alexis de Tocqueville Institution in Washington DC, suggests that most of the credit given to Linux actually belongs to MINIX, a UNIX-like operating system designed by Tanenbaum. Tanenbaum is a professor of Computer Science at Vrije University, Amsterdam.

The argument: If it took Tanenbaum three years to develop MINIX, despite years of experience with OSes and software development, how could Torvalds, a student with limited knowledge, develop Linux in six months?

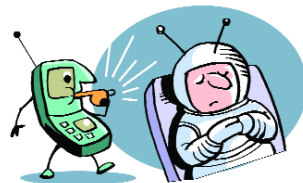
Both Tanenbaum and Torvalds contest the claims of the study. Tanenbaum has called Ken Brown, the president of Alexis Foundation "extremely evasive", on his home page (<http://www.cs.vu.nl/~ast/brown>). He thinks it possible that the Alexis Foundation might be funded by elements seeking to discredit Linux and its recent growth.

Our favourite extract from his home page is, "But the code was his (Torvalds'). The proof of this is that he messed the design up."



Intel, Linux and space

You're given a Pentium II running GNU Linux, and asked to put it to good use. What's the best thing you can do with it? How's this: You create a Personal Satellite Assistant



(PSA) that will remind space scientists of the correct procedure during experiments, warning them about the dangers, and keeping track of the day's jobs.

No, this isn't fiction, a prototype PSA has been developed by NASA's Ames Research Center. It took six years to do it, but the prototype has environmental sensors that check for oxygen and temperature levels; its onboard camera makes teleconferencing possible with mission control, it conveys experiment procedures via an inbuilt LCD panel and speaker.

Trust NASA to come up with a good use for all those old Pentium IIs lying about. Of course it remains to be seen whether this revolutionary development will ever be used, or, as with a lot of NASA's projects, be shelved for 'later' use.



heroes

Gmail

Everyone's talking about Gmail! Gmail invites are being auctioned online. Software such as Gmail Loader, and Pop Goes the Gmail have come up. Gmail has also forced many e-mail service providers to expand their storage.

Anti-spyware Legislation

A US House sub-committee recently approved what is an anti-spyware bill. The bill would allow for fines of up to \$3 million for redirecting users' browsers, gathering users' personal information, and displaying certain kinds of pop-up ads on users' computer screens, without their knowledge or consent.



zeroes

HMV

HMV, the popular UK music retailer, has begun selling iPod players on the music downloads section of its site. HMV does not have a tie-up with Apple. However, there's nothing funny or surprising about the fact that HMV is selling iPods. What is funny is that the iPod cannot play tracks downloaded from HMV's site!

Tablet PCs

Tablet PCs, much-hyped, have enjoyed only limited success so far, and only in specific market segments. This is according to a new report from In-Stat/MDR. And research firm IDC says that sales will go up from 500,000 in 2003 to 1 million this year, but that's only 0.5 per cent of the PC market. One reason could be—you guessed it—current pricing.